



SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

Complete Rule Book for SSC

All Rules with Examples, Exceptions & Common SSC Traps

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Basic Rule

A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb.

- She **writes** well.
- They **write** well.

All Rules

Rule 1: Subjects joined by “AND”

Two or more subjects joined by “and” usually take a plural verb.

- Ram and Shyam **are** friends.

Exceptions:

If the two nouns joined by “and” refer to the same person/thing, use a singular verb. **See the Note below.**

- The Secretary and Treasurer **is** absent. (one person holding both posts)

If preceded by “each,” “every,” or “many a,” use a singular verb even with “and.”

- Every boy and every girl **was** present.
- Many a man and woman **has** come.

If the subjects joined by “and” express a single idea or refer to a single unit, use a singular verb.

- Bread and butter **is** my breakfast.
- Slow and steady **wins** the race.
- Rice and curry **is** his favourite dish.



Important Note: when two articles (a/an/the) or possessive adjectives (my, our, your, his, her, etc.) are joined by “and”, they refer to two different persons/things.

- **The** director and **the** producer are here to promote the film. (Two different persons)
- **The** director and producer is here here to promote the film. (Same person)
- **My** brother and director is here to promote the film. (Same person, my brother is also a director)
- **My** brother and **the** director are here to promote the film. (Two different persons)
- **A** black and **a** white cats were there in the room. (Two cats, one black and one white)
- **A** black and white cat was there in the room. (One cat, which is black and white)

Rule 2: Subjects joined by “OR,” “NOR,” “EITHER...OR,” “NEITHER...NOR,” “NOT ONLY...BUT ALSO”

The verb agrees with the nearest subject (subject which is closest to the verb).

- He or I **am** wrong.
- Neither he nor his friends **were** invited.
- Either the manager or the employees **are** responsible.
- Neither the boys nor the girl **was** present.
- Not only the teacher but also the students **were** present.
- Not only the students but also the teacher **was** present.
- Not only I but also he **is** responsible.
- Not only he but also I **am** responsible.

Key point:

All five connectors — or, nor, either...or, neither...nor, not only...but also — follow the same proximity rule: check the subject right before the verb, ignoring the farther subject. SSC frequently places a plural noun first and a singular noun second (or vice versa) specifically to trap students who agree with the wrong (farther) subject.

Common SSC trap:

✗ Not only the players but also the coach were unhappy.

✓ Not only the players but also the coach was unhappy. (“coach” — singular — is nearer the verb)

Rule 3: Collective Nouns

Collective nouns (team, family, jury, committee, army, crowd, etc.) take a singular verb when the group acts as one unit, and a plural verb when members act individually / separately.

- The team **has** won the match. (acting as one unit)



- The team **are** divided in their opinions. (acting individually)
- The jury **has** given its verdict.
- The jury **were** divided in their opinion.

Rule 4: Indefinite Pronouns (always singular)

Each, every, either, neither, someone, somebody, something, anyone, anybody, anything, no one, nobody, nothing, everyone, everybody, everything, one — always take a singular verb.

- Everybody **is** happy.
- Neither of the answers **is** correct.
- Each of the students **has** submitted the assignment.

Rule 5: “Each” and “Every”

When “each” or “every” precedes subjects joined by “and,” the verb is singular.

- Each boy and each girl **has** a book.
- Every man, woman, and child **was** rescued.

Rule 6: Subjects with “along with,” “as well as,” “with,” “together with,” “besides,” “no less than,” “accompanied by,” “in addition to”

The verb agrees with the main / first subject only — the phrase in between is ignored.

- The teacher, along with the students, **is** going on a trip.
- Ram, as well as his friends, **was** present.
- The captain, together with his team, **is** ready.

Rule 7: “None”

“None” can take a singular or plural verb depending on meaning (traditionally singular, but plural is common and acceptable when referring to countable plural nouns).

- None of the students **has / have** finished the work. (both accepted in most exams — check context)
- None of the milk **has** been spilt. (uncountable → singular only)

Rule 8: Titles, Names, Distances, Amounts, Quantities, Time

When the subject refers to a single quantity / amount / distance / time as a whole, use a singular verb — even if the noun looks plural.

- Ten kilometers **is** a long distance.
- Fifty rupees **is** not enough.
- Two-thirds of the work **is** done.



- Gulliver's Travels **is** a great novel.
- The Ramayana **is** a Hindu epic.

Rule 9: Plural Nouns with Singular Meaning

Some nouns are plural in form but singular in meaning — they take a singular verb: Physics, Mathematics, Economics, Statistics, News, Civics, Ethics, Aesthetics, Innings, Gallows, Mumps, Measles, Rickets.

- Mathematics **is** an interesting subject.
- The news **is** shocking.
- No news **is** good news.

Note: "Statistics" can take a plural verb when it means "numerical data" — e.g., The statistics are alarming.

Rule 10: Nouns Always Plural (No Singular Form)

Scissors, trousers, spectacles, glasses, jeans, shorts, tongs, pliers, scales, alms, thanks, riches, etc. — always take a plural verb.

- The scissors **are** sharp.
- My trousers **are** torn.

Rule 11: "A number of" vs "The number of"

"A number of" (meaning "many") takes a plural verb.

- A number of students **were** absent.

"The number of" takes a singular verb.

- The number of students **is** increasing.

Rule 12: Subjects with "Percent / Percentage," "Fraction," "Portion," "Majority"

The verb agrees with the noun that follows "of."

- 50% of the work **is** done. (work — singular)
- 50% of the students **are** present. (students — plural)
- A majority of the members **were** in favour.
- The majority **was / were** in favour. (depends on unity or individuality)

Rule 13: "Either...or" / "Neither...nor" with Different Persons

The verb agrees with the subject nearer to it, and also matches person.

- Either you or I **am** mistaken.
- Neither you nor he **is** to blame.

**Rule 14: Relative Pronoun “Who / Which / That” as Subject**

The verb agrees with the antecedent of the relative pronoun.

- He is one of the boys who **play** well. (antecedent = boys → plural)
- He is the only one of the boys who **plays** well. (antecedent = one → singular)

Rule 15: Subject Following “There”

The verb agrees with the noun that follows “there is / are.”

- There **is** a book on the table.
- There **are** many books on the table.

Rule 16: Question Form with “Do / Does / Did”

The auxiliary agrees with the subject.

- **Does** he know?
- **Do** they know?

Rule 17: “One of” + Plural Noun

With “one of the + plural noun,” the real subject is “one,” so the verb is singular.

- One of the boys **is** absent. (subject = “one,” singular)
- One of my friends **has** won a prize.

Rule 18: Compound Subjects Treated as One Idea

- Bread and butter **is** served.
- The rise and fall of empires **is** inevitable.

Rule 19: “Many a”

“Many a” + singular noun takes a singular verb.

- Many a soldier **has** died in the war.

Rule 20: “Many”

“Many” + plural noun takes a plural verb.

- Many students **were** absent.

Note: “Many” and “many a/an” have the same meaning. “Many a/an” is more formal and is used in newspapers and literature.

**Rule 21: Countries and Organizations (as Single Entities)**

Names of countries / organizations, though plural in form, take a singular verb when referring to the entity as a whole.

- The United States **has** a strong economy.
- The United Nations **was** formed in 1945.

Rule 22: Sums of Money, Weights, Measurements as a Whole

- Five thousand rupees **is** a huge amount.
- Ten kilograms **is** the weight limit.

Rule 23: “As well as,” “rather than,” “no less than” Connecting Subjects of Different Number

The verb agrees with the first subject.

- The boy, rather than his parents, **is** to blame.

Rule 24: Subject–Complement Agreement

The verb agrees with the subject, NOT the complement.

- His only support **was** his parents. (subject = support, singular)
- My favourite pastimes **are** reading and writing.

Rule 25: “Nothing but / No one but / Anyone but” (BUT = except)

When “but” means “except” (a preposition, not a conjunction), the phrase after “but” is ignored for agreement. The verb agrees only with the main subject (nothing, no one, anyone, etc.), not with the noun following “but.”

- Nothing but cats **was** there in the room. (subject = “nothing” — singular)
- Nothing but a cat **was** there in the room.
- No one but the players **was** allowed inside.
- Nobody but his close friends **knows** the truth.

Don’t confuse with “not only...but also” (Rule 2):

In “not only...but also,” both parts ARE subjects, so the nearer-subject rule applies. In “nothing/no one/nobody + but” (meaning except), only the word before “but” is the subject — the phrase after “but” is dropped from agreement entirely.



SSC-Specific Tricky Areas to Watch

Intervening phrases: Ignore prepositional phrases that sit between the subject and the verb — agree with the true subject, not the noun closest to the verb in the sentence.

- The quality of these products **is** poor. (not “products are”)

Inverted sentences: When the subject comes after the verb, still make the verb agree with the true subject.

- Here **comes** the bus.
- Here **come** the buses.

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